the 15 years since, the ex-CM has had exponentially diminishing returns: 0, 10 and 0 seats in three Lok Sabha elections, and a starker fall in state polls. Ranking from the BSP's 2007 peak of 206 assembly seats out of UP's 403, she went from a losing 80 in 2012, to 19 in 2017, to a measly 1 in 2022.

That day, a couple of clear steps came from her. The BSP would go solo in 2027, she said. Two, verbal and visual cues confirmed Akash Anand, her young nephew, was back as her heir—

Takeaways

- **Mayawati makes a splash with her first big rally since 2021**
- **Says BSP will go solo in 2027. Nephew Akash projected heir**
- **Recent atrocities show her stewardship on Dalit issues as weak**

ending an erratic spell marked by an expulsion in March. Besides that, Behenji lit into the Samajwadi Party (SP) and Congress. Less expectedly, far from ducking the slur of being a 'B-team' of the BJP, she thanked the Yogi Adityanath regime for "maintaining the parks and memorials built by the BSP".

ELEPHANT AND CRAB

Naturally, questions followed. Opposition leaders alleged the BJP had quietly facilitated the event—to keep the BSP in play as an axis in state politics. If such suggestions are gaining currency, it owes to the sideways patterns the elephant's padded footprints have been making of late: drift and unpredictability with decisions, prevarication on the INDIA bloc, confused silence on the rise of alternate Dalit youth icons like Chandrashekhar Azad and, most notably, retreat from the mainstream of Dalit activism.

That last bit shone through in her response to the recent events in UP: only a nominal tweet on October 22, saying "all states" must stop anti-Dalit atrocities. The contrast with the forceful protector style of Azad has not gone unnoticed. And, dramatically enough, Rahul Gandhi was on the victim's lips in Rae Bareli—caught on video—and on the spot days later, meeting the family.

ELEPHANT AND CRAB

BSP leader Dr M.H. Khan says writing off the party in 2027 would be a big mistake. "Going solo is a totally correct step. Behenji is going to be the next CM. There were some shortcomings, and she has been continuously addressing them. Everyone is active, the rally was proof of this," he told INDIA TODAY.

Sceptics abound. Prof. R.K. Mishra, former head of political science at Lucknow University, feels compulsion rather than choice forces her hand. "The cases against her put her at the Centre's mercy. It has harmed her credibility—that shows in the recent vote shifts," he says.

Mayawati's old monopoly is indeed a bit shaky. In 2024, only 44 per cent of her 23 million-strong core Jatav base and 15 per cent of non-Jatav Dalits voted BSP. Overcoming a long antipathy for the SP, 25 per cent of Jatavs and an overwhelming 56 per cent of other Dalits voted for INDIA candidates. Mayawati knows, therefore, whom to mark out as Enemy No. 1. ■

▶ PUNJAB

IS IT FAITH ACCOMPLI IN TARN TARAN?

Part of the LS seat won by radical Amritpal in 2024, a bypoll tests the mood anew

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

IT MAY LOOK LIKE JUST ANOTHER assembly bypoll. But, for Tarn Taran, it's a vote that taps into questions of identity and belonging. Rajwinder Kaur, a young schoolteacher, expresses it well, walking past colourful posters of Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) candidate Harmeet Singh Sandhu and shaking her head: "We want development—roads, schools, clean water. But we cannot ignore who speaks for our community and faith."

A few streets away, elderly men in turbans chant slogans invoking Sikh pride, and young volunteers hand out leaflets urging panthic solidarity. The saffron-and-blue flags of the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) fluttering nearby



PRABHJOT GILL

RADICAL PICK Mandeep Singh (left), the Waris Punjab De candidate for Tarn Taran bypoll